

cern about terrorism. Rao deftly avoids any comment on it, but she would have to bring to bear all her diplomatic wiles when she meets her Pakistani counterpart Salman Bashir on the sidelines of the UN General Assembly session in New York next month. It may be of help to Rao that Bashir served with her in Beijing when she was the Indian envoy there.

One half of the power couple she makes with Karnataka Chief Secretary Sudhakar Rao, her ascent to the big league happened when she took over as the first woman spokesperson of the Foreign Office in 2001. In fact, after the attack on Parliament in December 2001, the Pakistani media regarded Rao as a major force in the psy-ops that India unleashed. She describes her new assignment as "complex yet fascinating". Complex it will be. Despite more than 12 rounds of boundary talks with China not much has moved, but old diplomatic warhorses believe she can make a difference. "She is the best foreign service officer who understands the geographical aspect of strategy and combines it with a unique balance of judgement," says

former foreign secretary S.K. Singh, now governor of Rajasthan. As former envoy to China, she will be required to make even more changes when India engages with China in the next round of boundary negotiations. India has been concerned with Beijing's aggressive stance on the Line of Actual Control: over 200 violations have been reported so far.

As India's global profile grows, India needs to learn to use public diplomacy as an instrument of foreign policy. Two years back, a public diplomacy division was set up but it has become a one-stop shop for providing funds to sustain some well-connected think-tanks and doling out favours to filmmakers. Ministry issues may also multiply when all the Indian envoys gather in Delhi for an annual brainstorming session later this month, but here too, she would need to be more receptive to their concerns. Besides, the new Government would increasingly need the foreign secretary's advice on policy. "She is a good housekeeper and can be an effective adviser on policy matters," says former foreign secretary Lalit Mansingh.

Another big issue will be to settle

the negotiations with the big boys on climate change. India may also be looking for US support on the expansion of the UN Security Council. It will have to engage its traditional ally Russia, which has been feeling left out. Reforming the MEA bureaucracy, which still seems to be living in a time warp is another challenge. According to a recent report by Daniel Markey, senior fellow at the Council for Foreign Relations, "For India to achieve great power status, a number of improvements to its foreign policy software will be required." These include expanding, reforming and training the IFS to attract and retain high calibre officers. The report also advocates getting specialists into the foreign service like in the US to tide over the problem of domain specialisation, which is pivotal especially on the issues of trade, energy and environment.

Rao seems to recognise that. "We need to attract the best of talent and augment the strengths of our foreign service to enhance our capabilities to meet the challenges of diplomacy in the 21st century," she says. However, this will not be easy, given that there will be resistance by the service officers who may feel left out if the specialists come in. Currently the only specialists in the legal division of the Foreign Office have a very limited window for growth. Even though last year, the Cabinet gave the go-ahead for an ambitious proposal to add 500 new posts, the service's strength of around 690 officers still lags behind its established counterparts like those of the US, France, UK and China.

Analysts believe that over the years the Foreign Office would need to work on a focused approach getting in right people for the right job. There is a need to get in a separate aptitude test at the entry level. Senior officials admit that Foreign Office is not attracting the best talent. Besides there are few avenues for on-the-job training to get a hang of the changes in international diplomacy. Rao's flair for creativity in the arts as well as diplomacy would help her tackle the ambitious agenda that awaits her. ■

STACKING UP

INDIA	USA	CHINA	UK	JAPAN
				
Diplomatic Budget: \$1.26 billion	Diplomatic Budget: \$16.3 billion	Diplomatic Budget: \$1.23 billion	Diplomatic Budget: \$3.75 billion	Diplomatic Budget: \$2.92 billion
Staff Strength: 3,514	Staff Strength: 19,667	Staff Strength: 4,500	Staff Strength: 3,600	Staff Strength: 5,500

MILES TO GO

- Get domain specialists and officials to deal with the new challenges of global diplomacy
- Increase the budget to meet India's global aspirations like the other big boys in the world
- Get experts and non-career officers into the Foreign Office with a clear mandate
- Get diplomats with the right skills, introduce an aptitude test before entry to the foreign service

DIPLOMATIC OUTREACH: OVER 150 MISSIONS AND POSTS